

CHAPTER 4

Needs

A need is life seeking expression within us.

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The word “need” implies *deficit* or *deficiency*. Given this negative undertone, sometimes we suppress our needs for fear of appearing “needy.” In doing so, we disconnect from the essence of life.

In NVC, needs refer to the conditions human beings require in order to be fulfilled and to thrive. Our needs include air, water, freedom, meaning, empathy, support, consideration, touch, honesty, and recreation. In some cases, the experience of an unfulfilled need may manifest as a physical sensation, such as hunger or thirst. At other times, it may take the form of a longing or yearning, as with empathy or meaning.

Needs are a two-way street. We want others to act in ways that help meet our needs, and we want to act in ways that help meet other people’s needs—for our own well-being. For instance, we need honesty from others, and we need to relate to others with honesty. The latter will enhance our peace of mind and protect our self-respect.

The concept of needs is the cornerstone of Nonviolent Communication and Empowerment Therapy (see Appendix 4.3 for an inventory of needs). Understanding that unmet needs are the root cause of clients’ suffering validates their emotions and gives them a vocabulary to address painful situations. The universality of needs makes it easier to connect across race, ethnicity, age, and other differences between therapist and client. Knowing our needs has many benefits.

EMPOWERMENT

Being aware of our needs is the first step toward meeting them, but this awareness requires some practice. Many of us disconnected from our needs in childhood. Often, when we expressed our needs, our caretakers did not listen, at best. At worst, they became

annoyed or irritated. “I didn’t ask if you were hungry. Put away that game and come to the table!” Children can continue to play, at the risk of stimulating anger in their parents, which could lead to disconnection and punishment, or they can comply and suppress their needs for choice and play. Confronted with the security and connection vs. freedom and autonomy dilemma, children often choose security, and the process of disconnection from needs begins. To avoid forcing such a dilemma, parents might opt to acknowledge their children’s needs and find a strategy that incorporates the needs of both parties. “OK, honey, how about you play five more minutes and then come to the table so we can have dinner together?”

Receiving the message that our needs don’t matter doesn’t only happen in childhood. Once during a team meeting at work, I was cold and asked, “Would anyone mind if I turn on the heater?” The director looked at me and said, in what seemed to me an angry tone of voice, “It’s not cold.” Period. No acknowledgement or accommodation of my needs whatsoever. No wonder we come to view our needs as toxic and disconnect from them!

It’s essential for clients to gain awareness of their needs in order to build more fulfilling lives. Otherwise, they might try multiple strategies to feel better to no avail. Take, for example, a client I had some time ago, who reported often feeling sad. When she did, she would go for a run or play lively music and dance to pull out of her sadness. Upon exploration, she discovered two unmet needs: connection with her husband and mourning the deaths of her parents. Uncovering her unmet needs and realizing that they are universal helped her address them. She began attending to these unmet needs, instead of lifting her mood temporarily.

Awareness of Choice We can discuss with clients the universal human need of autonomy and choice. Based on their upbringing, clients often don’t realize that they can *choose* to make changes in their lives. They go about their daily routines doing what they “have to do”—a semiconscious assumption that keeps them unhappy. Awareness of needs makes it easier for clients to restructure cognitive distortions, and the realization that they have choice empowers and liberates clients to make changes in their lives.

Dream Relationship Vision Borrowing from the work of Robert Fritz, when the situation calls for it in couples work, I invite each person to create a vision for their relationship. They think about what needs they would like to meet in a couple relationship and the specific ways in which they would like to meet them. I say, “Don’t hold back. Dream!” The exercise helps couples recognize the distance between their current place and their desired destination. As Fritz proposes, that recognition creates tension, not stress or anxiety but energetic tension, which calls for resolution. In this way, the tension between their current reality and what they want can, in itself, be a motivator to work toward their dream relationship. It helps them seek fulfillment proactively, rather than resign themselves to dissatisfaction and discontent.

This exercise is also a way for each person to gain clarity about what their partner wants. No guesswork is required. Once they each understand their partner's needs and wishes, the next step is to discuss how they feel about the strategies presented. It's important to clarify that each person can decide whether or not they want to support their partner in the *specific ways* requested. The strategies are not expectations or demands. They are requests subject to discussion.

Dream Life Vision When clients express dissatisfaction with their lives or when they are dealing with a specific issue, I invite them to imagine their dream life using the format of the Dream Relationship Vision above. The vision gives them clarity and motivation by establishing the distance between their current situation and what they desire.

INCREASED COOPERATION

Another benefit of knowing our needs is increased cooperation from others. When we express our needs, we are likely to access people's natural desire to contribute. The likelihood that our needs will be met increases significantly.

Revealing Our Needs When Making a Request Since needs are universal, when we express our needs to our clients and acknowledge their needs, we build a bridge that connects our minds and hearts. When we ask something of our clients, they are more likely to want to support us if they know what our needs are. Here are examples of how a standard request can be converted to an NVC request by making needs explicit:

Standard Requests

Susan, I would like all the group members to be in the room by 6:00, so that we can start the session promptly. Would you agree to arrive 5–10 minutes before 6:00? How would this be for you?

John, I have not received your payment for the last session. I like receiving payment at the end of each session. Would you be willing to do this? How would this be for you?

NVC Requests

Susan, I would like all the group members to be in the room by 6:00, so that we can start the session promptly. Once we start, quiet helps me focus and really hear people when they speak. For me, being on time is also a way to show respect for everyone in the group. Would you agree to arrive 5–10 minutes before 6:00? How would this be for you?

John, I have not received your payment for the last session. For ease and peace of mind, I like receiving payment at the end of each session. Would you be willing to do this? How would this be for you?

RELATIONSHIPS BASED ON CARE AND TRUST

Caring about the needs of others as much as our own is a way to live out an important principle of human relations. Nonviolent Communication offers a roadmap to embodying such care in our interactions with others. In doing so, we build trust.

The opposite is also true. When we care solely about our needs, we evoke distrust and lack of cooperation.

I was co-leading a nine-day NVC training. I asked a fellow trainer if he wanted to co-facilitate a session with me. “No,” he replied, “I don’t have enough trust that you care about my needs.” I was very surprised. That evening, reflecting on his words, I realized that the day before I had requested that he meet with a participant individually, without asking if this would be amenable to him. The next day I checked my guess with him. Indeed, that’s when the disconnect occurred.

Building trust in primary relationships is no different. It is crucial to help clients understand that identifying others’ needs is not enough. To build trust, it is necessary that we genuinely care about the needs of others and are willing to relinquish our preferred strategies and find ones that accommodate both parties’ needs. When others trust that we care about their needs, it’s easier for them to care about ours. This concept is particularly important in couples and family therapy.

NONVIOLENT CONFLICT RESOLUTION

When conflict arises, voicing needs helps transform separation into connection and makes it easier to find solutions that are amenable to both parties. Try this experiment: next time you have a conflict with someone, do your best to understand their feelings and needs in the situation and acknowledge them out loud. Remember, you may not get it right the first time, but keep trying until the other person confirms that you understand their feelings and needs. Then express your feelings and needs and watch the conflict de-escalate magically.

Conflict in relationships is arguably the most common presenting problem in therapy. We can support clients by sharing the concept of clarifying needs in individual, couples, and family therapy, as well as in therapy groups.

The following example illustrates what a talk with an adolescent would sound like if the mother were to acknowledge her son’s needs, express her own, and seek a strategy that considers both parties’ needs:

MOTHER: Luke, I get that you’re frustrated because you need freedom and trust. You want us to trust that you can take care of yourself and make wise choices. Am I with you on this?

SON: Yeah!

MOTHER: Is it also that you want to have fun and hang out with your friends for a good chunk of time?

SON: Yep.

MOTHER: Anything else?

SON: I'm the only one that has to be home by midnight. All my friends can stay out till 2:00 or 3:00 in the morning. I mean, the fun starts at 11:00!

MOTHER: And you want more leeway. You would like to have the same curfew as your friends?

SON: It would help.

MOTHER: Are you ready to hear me now? Or is there more you'd like me to hear?

SON: What?

MOTHER: Are you open to hearing my concerns?

SON: I guess.

MOTHER: I want you to have more freedom and have fun. And, at the same time, I want peace of mind, knowing that you're safe. Would you tell me what you heard me say?

SON: That you don't trust me.

MOTHER: Thank you for telling me what you heard. Let me clarify what I mean. I want you to have freedom and fun, and I want to have peace of mind. Would you tell me that back?

SON: That you want me to have fun and you want peace of mind.

MOTHER: Exactly, thank you. How do you feel hearing this?

SON: I don't know.

MOTHER: Are you frustrated, wanting a solution already?

SON: Yes.

MOTHER: I want a solution that leaves us both feeling satisfied. I want consideration for your needs *and* mine. Any ideas?

SON: I don't know. . . . What if I stay at Chuck's overnight when we hang out at his house? That way, I don't have to drive late at night. You and Mrs. Conway can talk about it.

MOTHER: That's a possibility. Let me give it a little thought on the weekend, when I have more space to think about it. We can talk on Sunday morning. How's that?

SON: Good.

MOTHER: Thank you for staying in the conversation, Luke. I'm relieved that we didn't end up arguing. I'm grateful because I like having harmony between us, and we came up with a solution that might work for both of us.

INCREASED INNER FREEDOM

There are many ways to meet our needs. Awareness of the possibilities enables us to trust in life's many resources and increases confidence. I'd like to share an example of how I was able to meet my needs in an atypical yet fulfilling way.

My husband and I didn't have children. For years, I mourned this situation. One day, talking to Marshall Rosenberg, he said "Myra, why do you want to have a child?" I replied, "Because I want to have someone in my life who is very close and who I can love, understand, and support." He said, "You don't need a biological child to meet those needs." He was right.

Now I have just such a chosen family: a beloved daughter, a son-in-law, and a granddaughter. I met my daughter at church 17 years ago, and we became very close. She calls me her spiritual mother. We talk once a week about matters of the heart. When I have faced great challenges, she has been a rock to me. I experience my son-in-law as caring and attentive. He invites me to their house frequently, cooks my favorite meals, and asks me to stay overnight. My granddaughter, currently 20, is a fun companion with whom I have enjoyed good food, the fine arts, and travel over the years. There are multiple ways to meet our needs. How liberating!

In addition, the realization that there are multiple ways to meet our needs has contributed to a sense of peace after my husband died. He met my needs for love and intimacy abundantly, but when he passed away, I was aware that he was not the only person in the world who could meet those needs. This understanding was a source of fortitude and calm. For more on this, see my grief model, Impermanence: A path to mourning losses in life (Appendix 1).

When we don't realize that there are multiple ways to meet a need, we become afraid and attached to our old, familiar strategies. This is one reason why people stay in destructive relationships. When people become aware that there are multiple ways to meet their needs, they are more free.

INCREASED EMPATHY AND UNDERSTANDING

All of our actions are attempts to meet needs. With this realization in mind, we are able to understand the actions of others, however baffling, and transform our judgments into empathic understanding. In NVC, we say that capturing and acknowledging the speaker's feelings creates 10% of the connection. The other 90% comes from understanding and acknowledging their needs. In ET, we aim for that same powerful connection with our clients, understanding their layers of meaning. When we as therapists have judgments about our clients' actions, identifying and connecting with the needs they are trying to meet is one way to restore unconditional acceptance.

INCREASED CONFIDENCE

Clarity about our needs is a powerful way to increase confidence in our actions. The following is another example of a situation from my own life.

Many years ago, I worked in a social service agency that I liked very much. Gradually my supervisor, a dear person to me, began to increase his expectations of me until my stress level was so high that I was losing sleep, unable to concentrate, and making mistakes while driving. One day, when he assigned me one more project, I said I couldn't do it and explained why. Clear about my need for self-care, I answered with conviction and without guilt, shame, or fear. Coming to an impasse, we asked a vice president to mediate. As it turned out, the vice president could understand my supervisor's point of view but not mine.

So, there I was, facing two people who held my livelihood in their hands. What to do? I listened empathically, explored other strategies to have the project done, but still would not agree to do it myself. That strength came from the clarity of my need. I knew that even if I was threatened with dismissal, I still needed to prioritize my health. That awareness empowered me to stand firm when it was difficult, rather than succumb to pressure and possibly become ill. Plus, burnout does not make for effective therapy work.

The end of the story is that I protected my health. My relationship with my supervisor was tense for a couple of weeks, but we recovered. After this conflict, I remained happily employed at the agency for several years.

Learning to recognize, embrace, and meet their needs is one of the most empowering concepts we can share with clients.

For several years, I led a group for Latina women in violent relationships. When they were able to recognize their needs and realize that everybody in the world has the same needs, they gained confidence and strength. Here are some of their insights:

“Ah, I’m not selfish to want to go out for coffee with my friends. I need to have fun!”

“I used to feel guilty coming to the group because my husband doesn’t like it. I don’t anymore. Now, I tell him, ‘I need support, I’ll be back at 8:15’ and leave.”

“Since we did the exercise about how we contribute to our families, I feel good about myself. I give a lot, and I want recognition.”

“I thought it was my duty to have sex when he wanted, so I made myself available and then got depressed. Not anymore. I decide about my body. I have a choice.”

At the same time, the women in the group learned to acknowledge their partners’ needs, which, not surprisingly, *increased their safety in the relationship*.

“Last night, my husband got mad that dinner wasn’t ready when he came home and started yelling. I said, ‘I get that you’re hungry; I’ll make you a snack. And I need respect. Would you please lower your voice?’”

When these women became clear about and embraced their inherent needs for safety, respect, having a voice, care, consideration, and autonomy, they no longer tolerated mistreatment. Most of the women I worked with reclaimed their dignity. They made radical changes in their relationships or separated from their partners.

People who are aware of, and *connected* to, their needs are freer. They don’t give in to the demands of others easily.

SEEMINGLY CONFLICTING NEEDS

At times, needs seem to be in opposition, as if one would have to choose between fulfilling one need over another. However, needs are never inherently in conflict; what can clash are the strategies we take to meet our needs. It’s important to realize that needs don’t conflict so that, when clients find themselves in a dilemma, we support them in finding ways to meet all the needs that are alive in the situation. Resigning themselves to live with unmet needs often represents a failure of imagination. An intuitive exploration can yield strategies that fulfill all the needs at play in a satisfying way.

Sometimes, upon deep soul searching, a client may choose to forego the fulfillment of one need in favor of another. In this case, they would grieve the pain of the unmet need and

come to peace with their decision. For instance, let's say that a client has chosen a religious life that calls for celibacy. She makes a conscious choice to forego her need for sexual expression in favor of her need for integrity. Notice, however, that sexual expression and integrity are not inherently in conflict. Both can coexist and be fulfilled harmoniously, generally. It is in the client's lifestyle choice that the conflict arises. The client could choose to leave the religious life, have a partner, and find another way to live out her religious beliefs. Alternatively, she could choose to stay in religious life and forego sexual expression. Either choice would call for mourning that can ultimately lead to peace. Married clients who fall in love with someone outside the marriage can find themselves in a similar predicament.

NEEDS VS. STRATEGIES

Strategies refer to the actions we take in order to meet our needs. It's important to separate needs from strategies because mixing the two results in making demands of others, which is likely to reduce their desire to support us.

We express needs in the abstract, without any reference to a person taking a specific action. For example: "I need connection" versus "I need you to stay home with me tonight." Connection is a need. Spending time with another person is one strategy to meet that need, but it is not the only one. Having this clarity helps us interact with others in ways that free them from the notion that they "have to" meet our needs. It also helps us be open to new ways to meet our needs.

In the therapeutic setting, being aware of this distinction helps us respond to clients in a way that supports their inner freedom. In the examples below, notice the difference between statements that mix needs with strategies and those that keep the two separate.

Mixing Needs with Strategies

You need her to listen to you with empathy.

Separating Needs from Strategies

You need empathy and you wish she could listen to you empathically.

You need him to connect with you.

You need connection. I'm guessing you would like him to tell you about his day during dinner, for example.

You need your daughter to cooperate and do her chores.

You need cooperation. You want your daughter to do her chores.

When we mix needs with strategies as in the statements on the left, the likelihood that our needs will be met decreases. The other person will likely hear that they have to comply and will probably want to protect their autonomy by refusing. Remember, as I explained in the Introduction, needs are nouns, not adjectives or verbs. For practice, separate needs from strategies by expressing each in separate sentence.

EXERCISE: NEEDS VS. STRATEGIES

Select the sentences that separate needs from strategies.

1. You need connection. I'm guessing you'd like to see her once a week.
2. You've said this before, and you need him to understand you.
3. I hear that you need touch and affection. I'm guessing you'd like him to hug and kiss you every day.
4. You need your supervisor to show respect for the staff.
5. I need consideration for my time. Would you agree to call me the day before when you're not going to come to the session?
6. I need help. Would you like to co-facilitate the group for children with ADHD?
7. You can't do it all alone. You need your family to cooperate.
8. You need honesty, and you want her to tell you exactly what happened.

9. I need dependability. Would you let me know ahead of time when your plans change?
10. You need respect for your autonomy. You wish she would ask, instead of telling you what to do?

Answers: 1, 3, 5, 6, 8, 9, and 10.

EXERCISE: UNDERSTANDING FEELINGS AND NEED

For each client statement below, try to guess the underlying feelings and needs. Respond tentatively, not declaratively, to allow the client to confirm or correct your understanding. In session, you would indicate the tentativeness of your response with your tone of voice or by framing it as a question.

1. I don't want to live anymore. I'm done with life.
2. I lost my job. I don't know what I'm going to do to pay my bills.
3. He is so inconsiderate!
4. Our house was burglarized on Wednesday.
5. I don't want to take antidepressants because they have side effects.
6. I got the promotion!
7. The receptionist was rude to me!
8. I get up in the morning, and an hour later I'm tired. I can't do anything!
9. I found out that my wife is cheating on me. I never thought she would do something like that.
10. I hit my daughter. I feel so bad.

The following are my responses to this exercise.

1. I'm guessing you're tired of hurting and you want out. You want relief and peace?
2. I'm hearing that you're very worried about the bills. You need basic security.
3. Are you angry, needing consideration and care?
4. I'm guessing you're scared because you lost a sense of safety in your own house. Is this how you feel?
5. I'm hearing that you're concerned because you want to protect your overall health and well-being. You don't want to fix one thing and harm another?

6. I'm guessing that you're thrilled that you have the recognition you have wanted for so long.
7. I'm hearing you're angry because you need to be treated with respect. Is this how you feel?
8. Are you discouraged, needing energy and vitality to function and get through the day?
9. I'm guessing you're devastated at the lack of honesty and respect for the marriage. And you're disappointed because you trusted her. Is this how you feel?
10. I'm hearing that you're feeling regretful because you want to relate to your daughter with respect and care. Is that it?

Take It to Your Practice

What needs does your therapy practice meet for you? What needs are not being met? What strategies could you try to tend to the unmet needs?

Invitation for Reflection

Cognitive distortions can lead to debilitating feelings. What could be the problem of addressing such distortions without identifying the underlying unmet needs?

SUMMARY

Needs are the conditions that human beings require in order to be fulfilled and to thrive. By recognizing our needs, we are empowered to build more fulfilling lives. Expressing our needs and acknowledging and caring about the needs of others increases cooperation and makes conflict resolution easier. Recognizing that there are multiple ways to meet our needs increases inner freedom. Understanding that beneath every action is an attempt to meet needs increases empathy and acceptance and helps us capture clients' various layers of meaning. Grounded in needs, we become more confident about our actions. Needs are abstract; they don't allude to specific persons or actions. Strategies are the concrete actions we take or would like others to take to meet our needs.